

First to Come, Last to Leave: Pre-Nomination Donors and the Durability of Legislators' PAC Coalitions

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Abstract

When do enduring relationships between organized interests and politicians form? I follow 74,230 PAC–member ties formed in the first winning campaigns of 814 House members elected between 1990 and 2016. Each month of earlier entry is associated with about a one-point lower per-cycle lapse probability. Pre-primary, or “seed,” ties are 6.3 points less likely to lapse than later ties, whose unadjusted lapse rate is 32 percent. Larger first-campaign contributions account for much of this difference. Local comparisons show no detectable primary-date discontinuity, including in contested races, although donors sort around nomination. Early and late donors respond similarly to relevant committee assignments. Early commitment predicts lasting support as candidates become officeholders.

Keywords: campaign finance; political action committees; primaries; Congress; interest groups.

1 Introduction

When do enduring relationships between organized interests and politicians form, and does the timing of first support predict how durable those relationships become? Two bodies of scholarship speak to these questions, though they emphasize different stages of the relationship. Research on campaign finance has documented the strategic logic of early political investment (Snyder, 1992; Bawn et al., 2012; Francia et al., 2003), while work on legislative–interest group relations has examined how organized interests maintain access to officeholders (R. L. Hall and Wayman, 1990; Kalla and Broockman, 2016; Fourniaies and A. B. Hall, 2018). What has received less attention is

the connection between these stages: when an interest first commits to a candidate, and whether that support remains distinctive once the candidate reaches Congress.

The period before nomination offers organized interests an opportunity to support future legislators before the fundraising advantages of incumbency accrue. Early money helps candidates build campaign organization, establish credibility, and attract further support (Biersack et al., 1993). For donors, committing at this stage may also establish a history of support that carries weight across a legislative career (Snyder, 1992; McCarty and Rothenberg, 1996). In the group-centered account of parties, these contributions help nominate candidates whose priorities align with those of the interests supporting them (Bawn et al., 2012; Hassell, 2018). The relationships that sustain legislators in office may therefore begin in the choices organized interests make before voters select a nominee.

This paper argues that the timing of first support is a meaningful signal of the commitment underlying a donor–legislator relationship. Donors who act early may help a candidate emerge and build a relationship through that support. They may also act early because they already know the candidate, share policy goals, or have information that other donors lack. Each explanation suggests that early support should be more durable. The question is whether that durability reflects a distinct commitment made before nomination, or a relationship whose strength precedes the campaign or develops gradually during it. The analysis examines these implications without treating the date of a contribution as direct evidence of donor intent.

To examine these questions empirically, I track PAC contributions to 814 House members first elected between 1990 and 2016, following their subsequent campaigns through 2018. I distinguish *seed donors*, who first contribute before the primary, from *bandwagon donors*, who begin afterward, and examine the broader timing of first support. The analysis follows individual PACs and the OpenSecrets interest categories to which they belong. Comparing early and late relationships within the same donor and election cycle allows me to assess whether timing predicts continued support beyond a donor’s general giving patterns and the conditions facing the recipient legislator. I then examine relationships formed around nomination, differences across contested and uncontested primaries, and responses to relevant committee assignments.

Earlier support predicts more durable relationships. Each additional month of earlier entry is associated with a 1.0 point lower per-cycle probability of lapse for PACs and a 0.7 point reduction for interests. Seed donors account for 24 percent of first-campaign PAC relationships but 37 percent of contributions. Their ties are 6.3 percentage points less likely to lapse in a reelection cycle, against an unadjusted bandwagon lapse rate of 32 percent; for interests, the difference is 4.6 points against 20 percent. Among relationships receiving similar first-campaign amounts, these differences fall to

2.6 and 1.7 points. The timing gradient is steeper among members who faced a primary opponent, but does not clearly vary with the closeness of the contest. Local comparisons show no detectable break at the primary, including in contested races, although donors sort around that date. Nor is the seed difference larger among members who previously held elected office. Both early and late donors increase giving when members hold relevant committee seats, by 6.8 points for interests and 7.8 points for PACs, with no detectable difference in responsiveness.

These findings connect the formation of financial coalitions to their persistence across legislative careers. Early donors give more and sustain support longer, including when compared with the same organization's later relationships. The pattern is consistent with long-term investment, but does not establish that giving early creates the attachment. Relationships formed before the campaign and commitment developed through repeated support remain possible explanations. By following first-campaign coalitions, comparing relationships within donors, and examining the timing of entry around nomination, the paper shows what early support reveals about the relationships that endure.

2 Literature, Theory, and Hypotheses

2.1 Money, Primaries, and the Establishment of Viability

Securing sufficient funds is essential for candidates running for office, both to finance campaign activities and to signal viability. Fundraising is particularly informative in congressional races, where voters often know little about the candidates (Feigenbaum and Shelton, 2013; Case and Porter, 2026). Early support allows candidates to organize, reach voters, and attract additional money, endorsements, and attention (Biersack et al., 1993; Francia et al., 2003). Among political newcomers, it predicts later fundraising and primary success (Porter and Steelman, 2023), although the measurement of early money affects these conclusions (Case and Porter, 2026). The source of contributions also shapes perceptions of electability (Anderson et al., 2026). PACs therefore make decisions about when, as well as whom, to support, and early contributions may carry expectations that extend beyond the current election (McCarty and Rothenberg, 2000; Box-Steffensmeier et al., 2005).

The importance of early money is especially clear in primaries. Candidates from the same party must distinguish themselves without the partisan cue that structures general elections (Herrnson, 2015; Hirano and Snyder, 2019). Challengers face incumbents with established name recognition and fundraising networks (Ansolabehere and Snyder, 2002), while open-seat candidates may compete in crowded fields (Hassell, 2018). Early funding helps newcomers establish credibility before voters settle on a candidate (Porter and Steelman, 2023). Those who raise little may withdraw before

the primary (Thomsen, 2023), and party networks use this period to coordinate behind preferred candidates (Hassell, 2016; Hassell, 2018). Campaign money can thus shape which candidates remain viable, a role also suggested by evidence from corporate contribution bans in state elections (A. B. Hall, 2016).

A primary victory is a public signal that the candidate has secured the nomination and advanced to the general election (Bawn et al., 2012; Hirano and Snyder, 2019). Seed donors commit before that result is known; bandwagon donors can respond to it. This difference gives nomination theoretical importance, but its informational value varies across races. A candidate with a token opponent may already be the likely nominee, and an uncontested primary may resolve little uncertainty. The primary date identifies a stage in the electoral process, rather than a uniform change in every candidate's prospects.

2.2 Why Donors Give Early

Why would organized interests commit resources before nomination? The answer depends on both the relationships donors already have and those they hope to build. Several explanations may operate together.

Early giving may continue a relationship that predates the campaign. Candidates draw on professional, business, and civic networks to raise funds (Francia et al., 2003). A PAC may know a candidate through state legislative service, work in its industry, or local political activity. In these cases, the first contribution observed in a House campaign records financial support within an existing relationship.

Early donors may also have better information. Local employers, unions, and organizations with members in the district may know more about a candidate's prospects than national groups (Porter and Steelman, 2023). They can commit earlier because they have greater confidence in whom they are supporting. Giving before a public signal of viability does not imply that the donor itself lacked information.

Other donors may use early giving to build a relationship or shape the choice of nominee. Supporting a candidate before the pool of contributors widens establishes a history of commitment that can distinguish the donor from those who follow (Francia et al., 2003; Kalla and Broockman, 2016). Donors may also identify candidates who share their priorities (Bonica, 2014), while considering district competitiveness and the alternatives in the race (Meisels et al., 2024). In the group-centered account of parties, organized interests act as stakeholders in nomination, allocating resources to candidates they expect to represent their policy goals. Screening before election is important because these groups have fewer means of disciplining legislators afterward (Bawn et al.,

2012; Hassell, 2016; Hassell, 2018). Early support can therefore help determine both who reaches office and which interests enter that legislator's coalition.

These explanations imply that early contributions can reveal the strength of a relationship without uniquely identifying its origin. Seed donors may invest in future access, and bandwagon donors may seek lasting relationships as well (Snyder, 1992; Kalla and Broockman, 2016). The distinction between them is when support begins. Whether this distinction predicts continued giving is an empirical question; whether it reflects prior attachment or commitment built through the campaign requires additional evidence.

2.3 Campaign Contributions as Long-Term Investments

Campaign contributions can be understood as investments whose returns develop over a legislative career. Snyder (1990) and Snyder (1992) models giving as a long-term investment sustained through repeated support. McCarty and Rothenberg (1996) show that commitment problems limit what donors and politicians can exchange, making continuing relationships valuable. PACs often support the same incumbents across elections (Romer and Snyder, 1994). Evidence from Colombian mayoral elections likewise suggests that continued giving depends on personal loyalty and the realization of expected returns (Rueda and Ruiz, 2025). The relevant unit of commitment is therefore a relationship that extends across elections, rather than a single contribution.

Lasting support can still respond to changes in a legislator's institutional position. Contributions follow relevant committee assignments (Kroszner and Stratmann, 1998; Powell and Grimmer, 2016; Fournaies and A. B. Hall, 2018), facilitate access (Kalla and Broockman, 2016), and support committee effort by sympathetic legislators (R. L. Hall and Wayman, 1990). Evidence that contributions buy favorable policy is mixed (Fournaies and Fowler, 2022), while corporate PACs respond to the policy positions of primary winners (Meisels, 2026). A donor may remain attached to a legislator while adjusting the amount or frequency of support as the expected value of the relationship changes.

Incumbency changes the setting in which these relationships operate. It broadens the pool of willing contributors (Fournaies and A. B. Hall, 2014), while campaign finance rules affect legislators' incentives to remain in office (Weschle, 2021). Seed donors begin giving before those fundraising advantages accrue. If early commitment establishes a distinctive relationship, their support should remain more durable even as the member attracts new contributors.

2.4 Expectations for Continued Support

The investment account predicts that seed donors sustain support longer because they committed at an earlier stage of candidate emergence. A history of backing a candidate through nomination may create familiarity, trust, and obligations that carry into office (Snyder, 1992; McCarty and Rothenberg, 1996). A sharp version of this argument places particular weight on the primary: if nomination separates relationships of different character, contributions made immediately before and after it should predict different levels of durability. This *nomination threshold* prediction should be most apparent where the primary resolves uncertainty. It is a narrower implication than the broader claim that political investment builds lasting relationships.

A broader account emphasizes *selection and cumulative commitment*. Donors with closer connections, stronger policy agreement, or better information may begin earlier and remain longer. Relationships may also deepen gradually as support accumulates during the campaign. Both processes predict greater durability with earlier entry, without requiring a break at the primary. A continuous relationship between timing and persistence would therefore remain consistent with investment, while leaving its role relative to prior attachment unresolved.

I examine these arguments through four expectations. Seed relationships should be less likely to lapse (H1) and more likely to resume after a break (H2). A sharp nomination-threshold account predicts a change in durability at the primary, particularly in contested races; a gradual account predicts a continuous timing pattern (H3). Finally, if early commitment makes support less dependent on institutional access, seed donors should respond less strongly to relevant committee assignments (H4). Similar committee responses would suggest that the greater durability of early relationships can coexist with responsiveness to a member's institutional position.

3 Data, Variables, and Methods

3.1 Members, donors and ties

The sample includes 814 members who first won House seats as non-incumbents in general elections from 1990 through 2016. I identify them using FEC candidate files and EveryPolitician membership records.¹ Contributions come from FEC itemized committee-to-candidate records (Federal Election Commission, 2026). I analyze individual PACs and aggregate their contributions into OpenSecrets interest categories (OpenSecrets, 2023). Records for the 2014–2018 cycles were rebuilt from FEC bulk files using filters that reproduce 99.9 percent of the earlier cleaned records.

¹I exclude members first elected through special elections and retain returning members in their first cohort only.

A *tie* is a donor–member pair formed in the member’s first winning cycle. A tie is a *seed* tie if its first contribution in that cycle precedes the state’s first primary; otherwise, it is a *bandwagon* tie. Donors giving both before and after the primary are classified as seed donors. Nine percent of bandwagon PAC ties begin after the general election but within the same cycle; I also report results that treat them as a separate category (Online Appendix Table A9). In runoff states, I use the first primary date and assess sensitivity by excluding those states (Online Appendix Table A8). As a benchmark, I also examine *incumbency entrants*: donors first contributing in a later election cycle.

I measure primary contestation using returns compiled by Porter and Treul (2023). The data match 777 of the 814 members, with usable primary returns for 774. A primary is *contested* if another candidate appeared on the member’s party ballot. Of these members, 632 faced an opponent, and their median margin over the runner-up was 14 points. The data also record whether members previously held elected office (68 percent) or served in a state or federal legislature (50 percent). As an alternative covering all members, I identify a financially active rival when another same-party candidate registered with the FEC for the district raised at least \$5,000. This measure captures rival fundraising rather than actual ballot contestation.

PACs allow me to study repeated decisions by firms, trade associations, unions, and ideological organizations and to compare the same organization’s early and late relationships. Individual contributors fall outside this analysis. Table 1 describes 74,230 PAC ties and 45,911 interest ties. Seed ties account for 24.0 percent of PAC relationships and 36.7 percent of first-campaign PAC dollars. Their median first-campaign amount is \$2,500, compared with \$1,000 for bandwagon ties. Unions account for 22 percent of seed interest ties but 12 percent of bandwagon interest ties.

3.2 Tenure and durability

I follow each tie through the member’s subsequent elections. A member is at risk in election $k \geq 2$ if the FEC candidate files list the member as an incumbent House candidate in that cycle, so eligibility is independent of contribution receipts. Cycles in which every founding donor stops giving are therefore retained, and contributions are observed whether or not the member won that cycle. I define tenure as consecutive incumbent candidacies following the first victory; 751 members have at least one reelection in the window.² A tie *lapses* in the first election $k \geq 2$ within tenure in which the donor gives nothing, and ties that never lapse are right-censored at the end of tenure or of the window. This produces a discrete-time hazard of a first lapse (Box-Steffensmeier and Jones, 2004),

²Fifteen incumbent candidacies received no PAC money from any donor. Excluding them, or counting a cycle only if some first-campaign donor gave (which drops cycles in which all founding donors lapse), leaves the estimates essentially unchanged (Online Appendix Table A5).

Table 1: Seed and bandwagon ties in members' first campaigns

	Seed	Bandwagon
<i>A. Interest groups</i>		
Ties	12,611	33,300
Share of first-campaign ties (%)	27.5	72.5
Share of first-campaign PAC dollars (%)	46.3	53.7
Median first-campaign amount (\$)	5,000	1,500
Member won an open seat (%)	76.8	70.7
Industry donors (% of ties)	71.1	79.8
Policy donors (% of ties)	7.4	7.9
Union donors (% of ties)	21.6	12.3
<i>B. Individual PACs</i>		
Ties	17,813	56,417
Share of first-campaign ties (%)	24.0	76.0
Share of first-campaign PAC dollars (%)	36.7	63.3
Median first-campaign amount (\$)	2,500	1,000
Member won an open seat (%)	77.4	71.9
Industry donors (% of ties)	68.7	76.9
Policy donors (% of ties)	7.4	7.7
Union donors (% of ties)	23.8	15.3

Ties are donor–member pairs formed in the member's first winning cycle (1990–2016 cohorts, elections through 2018). Seed ties began before the state's first primary; bandwagon ties began after it in the same cycle. Donor-type rows give the composition of each group (columns sum to 100).

estimated as a linear probability model on donor–member $\times$ election observations:

$$\text{Lapse}_{dmk} = \beta \text{Seed}_{dm} + \alpha_{m \times k} + \gamma_{d \times t} + \delta_{d \times p(m)} + \varepsilon_{dmk}, \quad (1)$$

where d indexes donors, m members, k the member's election number, t the calendar year and $p(m)$ the member's party. Standard errors are clustered by member and donor. In the timing models, the seed indicator is replaced by months of entry before the primary.

The fixed effects allow me to compare relationships while accounting for conditions shared by members and donors. Member $\times$ election effects compare donors supporting the same legislator in the same cycle, holding constant competitiveness, committee position, and other member-level conditions. Donor $\times$ year effects account for a donor's overall giving patterns in each cycle, while donor $\times$ party effects account for differences across recipient parties. The seed estimate therefore draws on comparisons between the same donor's early and late relationships as well as between donors supporting the same member. Most donors have both types of relationship: 343 of 385

interest categories account for 99.7 percent of interest ties, and 2,317 PACs account for 92.8 percent of PAC ties.

The same donor may nevertheless have a closer prior connection or stronger policy agreement with one candidate than another. These differences may affect both when it begins giving and how long it continues. I interpret β as the association between seed status and durability conditional on the fixed effects. The timing analyses examine whether this association changes around nomination; they do not identify the causal effect of early support.

3.3 Contribution size

Seed donors contribute more during the first campaign, raising the question of how timing and the size of commitment relate to continued support. Earlier entry provides more time to give, and larger contributions may themselves reflect stronger attachment. I therefore report models with and without 20 quantile bins of first-campaign amount. Table 2 pools these bins across elections, while the timing models interact them with election number; the latter specification yields slightly different seed coefficients. The adjustment compares relationships receiving similar amounts without identifying how much of the timing association is mediated by contributions. In the timing models, I also account for the amount of the first contribution.

3.4 Interests and PACs as units

I examine both PACs and interests because they capture different forms of continuity. OpenSecrets categories group PACs representing related interests, such as commercial banks or physicians. Continued giving by an interest means that at least one PAC in that category supports the member, even if the contributing organization changes. Continued giving by a PAC follows the same organization over time. A difference between the two levels need not imply coordination among PACs. I report both sets of estimates with their baseline lapse rates.

3.5 Entry timing, committee relevance and donor location

I measure entry timing as days before the state's first primary, expressed in months for the timing models; positive values indicate earlier entry. In the terms of Case and Porter (2026), the measure is election-centered because it dates support against a shared electoral event rather than the candidate's own fundraising start. Their distinction between candidate- and election-centered measures concerns different quantities of early fundraising. Here I apply that distinction to the start of donor–member relationships. A primary-relative measure fits the question of whether support before nomination

predicts durability, while the continuous measure examines variation within and across the two periods. A candidate-centered alternative dates entry against the candidate's first observed PAC receipt (Section 4.6).

A member holds a *relevant committee seat* if, in the Congress preceding the election, the member serves on a committee with jurisdiction over the donor's industry. A hand-coded crosswalk links OpenSecrets industries to committees: for example, commercial banks to Financial Services, and oil and gas to Energy and Commerce and Natural Resources. Assignments come from Stewart and Woon (2017) and match 97 percent of member-Congresses. Relevance is defined independently of contribution patterns. A PAC is *in-state* if its registered state matches the member's state; an interest category is in-state if more than half of its first-cycle contributing PACs meet that criterion.

4 Results

4.1 Seed ties are more durable

To assess whether seed donors sustain support longer, I begin with the probability that a relationship lapses for the first time. Table 2 reports estimates among ties still giving in the preceding cycle. Raw lapse rates are 19.8 percent for bandwagon interest ties and 13.5 percent for seed ties; the corresponding PAC rates are 32.1 and 25.0 percent. The pattern holds across the fixed-effect specifications. In column 4, seed interests are 4.6 percentage points less likely to lapse per cycle, and seed PACs are 6.3 points less likely. Complementary log-log models yield hazard ratios of 0.67 and 0.73, respectively (Online Appendix Table A3).

Figure 1 traces continued support across legislators' careers. By the fourth election, 66.3 percent of seed interest ties have never lapsed, compared with 54.0 percent of bandwagon ties. At the PAC level, 45.6 percent of seed ties remain uninterrupted, compared with 36.1 percent of bandwagon ties. Continued giving also remains more common among longer-serving members. For the 248 members observed for at least six elections, 69 percent of seed interests give in the sixth election, compared with 56 percent of bandwagon interests. Seed interests' share of founding-coalition dollars declines from 47 to 39 percent over this period (Online Appendix Figure A4).

Larger first-campaign contributions account statistically for much of the seed difference. Adding amount bins reduces the seed coefficient to 1.7 points for interests and 2.6 points for PACs (column 5), approximately a 60 percent reduction. Figure 2 examines when the remaining difference appears, allowing the amount bins to vary by election. Seed interests are 2.7 points less likely to lapse at the first reelection, and seed PACs are 3.2 points less likely, against bandwagon baseline rates of 25 and 39 percent. By the sixth election, the differences among similar-size ties are about one point. Seed

Table 2: Seed ties and the per-cycle hazard of a first lapse

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>A. Interest groups (bandwagon lapse rate 19.8%)</i>						
Seed	-5.7*** (0.5)	-7.7*** (0.5)	-5.4*** (0.4)	-4.6*** (0.4)	-1.7*** (0.4)	-1.1 (0.7)
Seed × open seat						-0.8 (0.8)
Observations	130,496	130,495	130,479	129,997	129,997	129,997
<i>B. Individual PACs (bandwagon lapse rate 32.1%)</i>						
Seed	-5.8*** (0.5)	-7.9*** (0.5)	-6.5*** (0.4)	-6.3*** (0.4)	-2.6*** (0.3)	-1.9** (0.6)
Seed × open seat						-0.9 (0.7)
Observations	164,355	164,354	163,504	156,340	156,340	156,340
Election number, cohort FE	Yes					
Legislator FE		Yes	Yes			
Donor FE			Yes			
Legislator × election FE				Yes	Yes	Yes
Donor × year, donor × party FE				Yes	Yes	Yes
First-campaign amount (20 bins)					Yes	Yes

Linear probability models on donor–member pairs × re-election cycles, from the member’s second election to the first cycle in which the donor gives nothing while the member is in office (1990–2016 cohorts, elections through 2018). Coefficients in percentage points; standard errors two-way clustered by legislator and donor in parentheses. Column (1) also controls for open seat, party and donor type. Columns (5)–(6) add 20 quantile bins of first-campaign amount, pooled across elections. $^+p < 0.1$, $^*p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$.

coefficients remain negative across donor types, race types, parties, and decades (Online Appendix Table A4).

4.2 Interpreting the size of the difference

Two comparisons put these differences in context. First, seed ties are a small share of all relationships members accumulate. Across the observation window, they account for 7 percent of PAC–member ties and 14 percent of their dollars. Bandwagon ties account for 21 and 27 percent, and incumbency entrants for 73 and 59 percent. In raw terms, incumbency entrants have the highest lapse rate: 44 percent, compared with 32 percent for bandwagon and 25 percent for seed ties. After accounting for member × election, donor × year, and tie-age differences, incumbency entrants are slightly less likely to lapse than bandwagon ties (1.0 points for PACs and 1.7 for interests). Seed ties remain more distinctive, with corresponding differences of 6.0 and 4.9 points (Online Appendix Table A6).³

³These linear probability models follow ties from their first contribution through the first lapse. Pooled amount bins reduce the differences, consistent with Table 2.

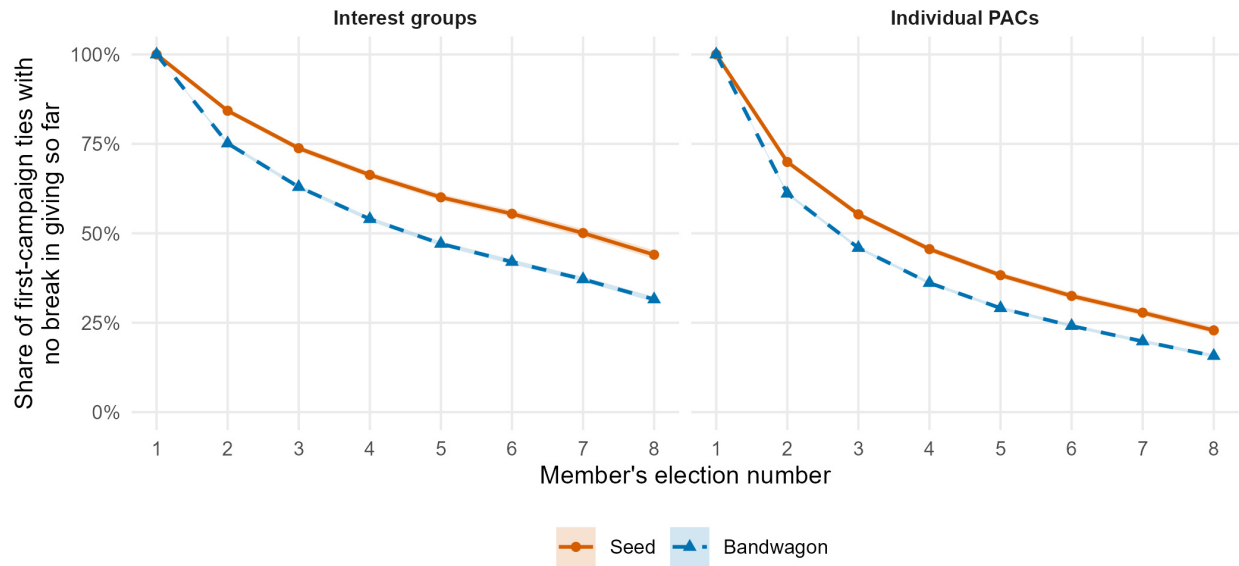


Figure 1: Share of first-campaign ties with no break in giving, by the member's election number. Kaplan–Meier estimates. Ties are censored at the end of the member's tenure (consecutive incumbent candidacies) or of the window (2018).

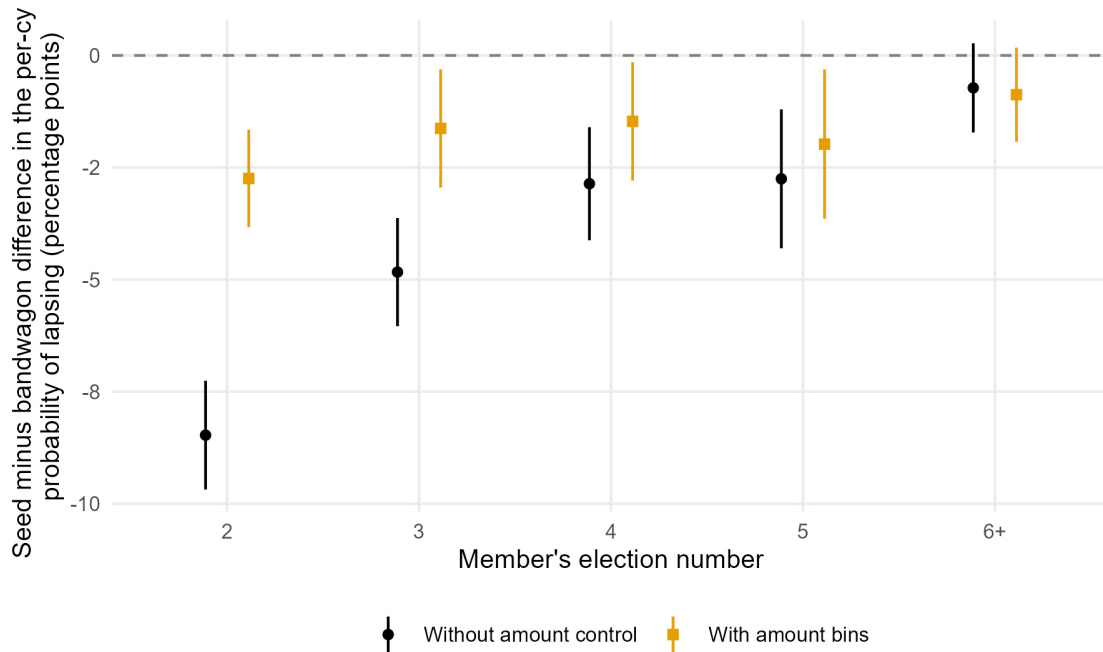


Figure 2: Seed minus bandwagon difference in the per-cycle probability of a first lapse, in percentage points, by the member's election number (interest level). Legislator $\times$ election, donor $\times$ year and donor $\times$ party fixed effects; the second series adds 20 first-campaign amount bins interacted with election number. 95% confidence intervals.

Early support therefore predicts durability beyond the distinction between giving before and after a member takes office.

The 5–6 point seed difference is also similar in magnitude to the association between relevant committee assignments and giving (Section 4.5), a familiar pattern in PAC research (Kroszner and Stratmann, 1998; Fourinaies and A. B. Hall, 2018). Because the outcomes and risk sets differ, this comparison provides a sense of scale rather than an equivalence of effects. The retention estimates show the cumulative difference more directly. By the fourth election, seed ties are 9 to 12 percentage points more likely to remain uninterrupted. Among long-serving members, seed interests still provide about two-fifths of founding-coalition dollars a decade after entry.

Donor portfolio breadth. Are early donors more selective in the candidates they support? Seed and bandwagon PACs fund similar numbers of other winners in the same cycle, with medians of 87 and 80. The durability difference is nevertheless larger among PACs supporting fewer candidates. In the bottom quartile, with a median of 11 other winners funded, seed ties are 8.1 points less likely to lapse; among similar-size ties, the difference is 2.9 points. In the broadest quartile, with a median of 210 other winners, the differences are 2.8 and 0.9 points (Online Appendix Table A7). Early entry predicts durability more strongly when the PAC’s support is concentrated among fewer candidates.

Open seats and challengers. The conditions surrounding early support may also matter. Open-seat donors choose among potential nominees, while donors to challengers must assess the prospect of defeating an incumbent. I find no clear difference in the seed advantage between these entry routes. The seed $\times$ open-seat interaction is small and insignificant (Table 2, column 6). Fourth-election interest retention is 66 versus 53 percent among open-seat winners and 68 versus 56 percent among challengers. Among similar-size ties, the seed advantages are 1.7 and 2.0 points, respectively (Online Appendix Table A4).

4.3 Resuming Support after a Lapse

A relationship may endure even when support is interrupted. I therefore examine whether seed donors are more likely to return after a lapse (Table 3). Among ties with time remaining in the member’s tenure, 60.7 percent of seed interest ties resume, compared with 53.3 percent of bandwagon ties; PAC rates are 41.7 and 37.1 percent. With donor and member–election fixed effects, seed interests are 2.7 points more likely to resume per cycle, declining to 1.7 points after amount adjustment. The PAC difference is 1.2 points and becomes insignificant after that adjustment. Among similar-size ties, the estimated interest-level advantage is 2.1 points (SE 0.7) for open-seat winners and –0.6 (1.4)

for challengers (column 5). The subgroup estimates suggest stronger resumption among open-seat winners, although the interaction provides only weak evidence that the groups differ. At the interest level, renewed giving can come from any PAC in the category. The stronger result at this level need not reflect coordinated behavior.

Table 3: Resuming support after a lapse

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
<i>A. Interest groups (share of lapses that resume: seed 60.7%, bandwagon 53.3%)</i>					
Seed	3.6*** (0.8)	3.6*** (0.7)	2.7*** (0.6)	1.7** (0.6)	-0.6 (1.4)
Seed × open seat					2.7+ (1.6)
Seed difference in open seats					2.1** (0.7)
Observations	42,167	42,162	41,635	41,635	41,635
<i>B. Individual PACs (share of lapses that resume: seed 41.7%, bandwagon 37.1%)</i>					
Seed	1.2** (0.4)	1.7*** (0.4)	1.2*** (0.3)	0.3 (0.3)	-0.5 (0.9)
Seed × open seat					0.9 (0.9)
Seed difference in open seats					0.5 (0.3)
Observations	119,822	119,421	109,210	109,210	109,210
Election number, cohort FE	Yes	Yes			
Legislator FE, donor FE		Yes			
Legislator × election, donor × year FE			Yes	Yes	Yes
First-campaign amount (20 bins)				Yes	Yes

Linear probability models of giving again, on pair × cycle rows after the first lapse while the member remains in office, until the donor gives again. All models control for cycles since the lapse (top-coded at 4); column (1) also controls for open seat, party and donor type. “Seed difference in open seats” is the linear combination seed + seed × open seat from column (5). Coefficients in percentage points; standard errors two-way clustered by legislator and donor. 1990–2016 cohorts, elections through 2018.

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

4.4 Entry timing and durability around the primary

Does the timing of first commitment matter only because it distinguishes seed from bandwagon donors, or does support become more durable with each month of earlier entry? Figure 3 compares lapse probabilities by month of first contribution, using the month after the primary as the reference group. PAC ties beginning at least a year before the primary are 7.4 points less likely to lapse per cycle. Those beginning in the month before it are 1.4 points less likely, while ties beginning at least six months afterward are 6.4 points more likely. Accounting for the first contribution’s amount

changes the gradient little; accounting for the first-cycle total reduces it by roughly half.

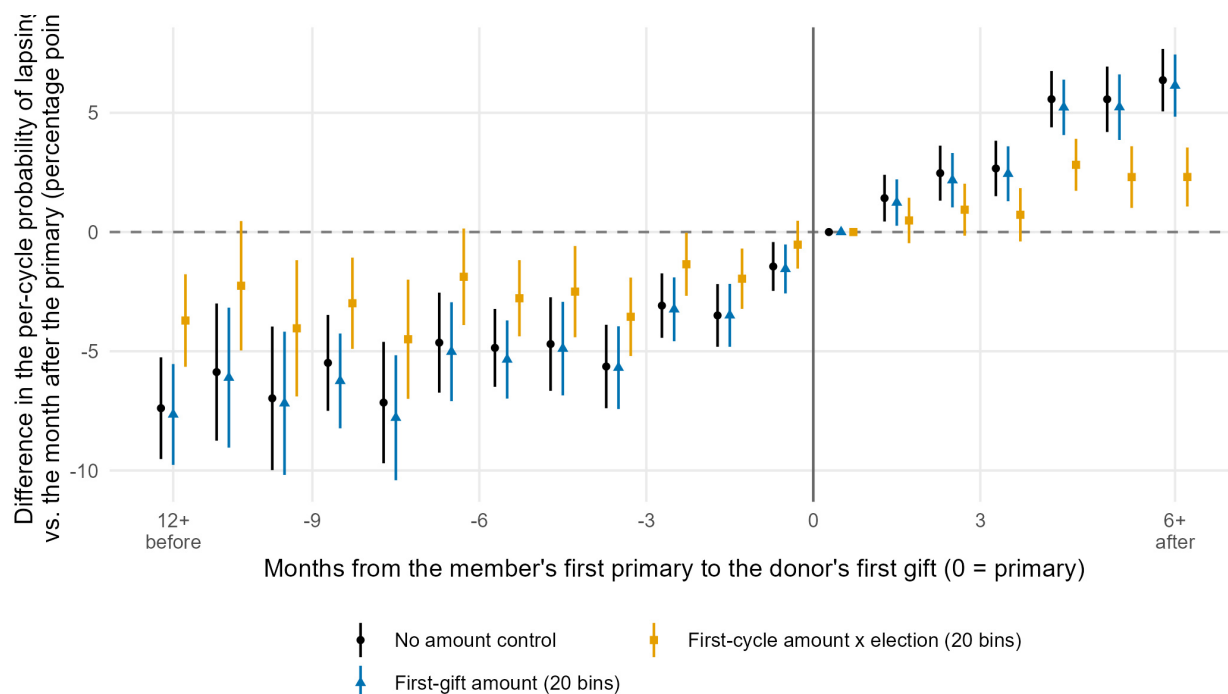


Figure 3: Per-cycle hazard of a first lapse by month of the donor’s first contribution, relative to the month after the primary, in percentage points (PAC level; base rate 28.6%). Legislator $\times$ election, donor $\times$ year and donor $\times$ party fixed effects, with no amount control, 20 bins of the first contribution’s amount, or 20 bins of first-cycle amount interacted with election. 95% confidence intervals.

Table 4 summarizes this pattern. Each additional month of earlier entry is associated with a 0.72 point lower lapse probability for interests and a 0.96 point reduction for PACs. Adding linear timing to the seed model reduces the seed coefficient by 78 percent for interests and 74 percent for PACs. Much of the binary distinction therefore reflects a broader relationship between when support begins and how long it continues. Separate slopes show a steeper gradient after nomination: each month of later post-primary entry is associated with a 1.1 to 1.2 point increase in lapse probability, compared with 0.3 to 0.5 points per month before the primary. The timing of entry during the general-election campaign is especially informative about subsequent withdrawal.

The post-primary pattern is not driven by the 9 percent of bandwagon ties that begin after the general election. These donors give once the winner is known, but their relationships are more durable than those beginning during the general-election campaign. Their raw PAC lapse rate is 25.0 percent, the same as seed ties, compared with 32.9 percent for ties formed between the primary and general election (Online Appendix Table A9). With months of entry bottom-coded at six months after the primary, post-election entrants flatten the estimated slope. Excluding them steepens the PAC slope to 1.5 points per month and leaves the seed coefficients essentially unchanged (–6.4 and

Table 4: Entry timing and the hazard of a first lapse

	Interest groups		Individual PACs	
	No amount	Amount bins	No amount	Amount bins
<i>Seed indicator alone</i>				
Seed	-4.61*** (0.40)	-1.84*** (0.35)	-6.26*** (0.38)	-2.68*** (0.32)
<i>(a) Linear entry timing</i>				
Months before primary	-0.72*** (0.06)	-0.31*** (0.05)	-0.96*** (0.06)	-0.45*** (0.05)
<i>(b) Piecewise, kink at the primary</i>				
Months before, pre-primary entry	-0.34*** (0.08)	-0.18* (0.07)	-0.53*** (0.08)	-0.31*** (0.07)
Months before, post-primary entry	-1.10*** (0.11)	-0.48*** (0.10)	-1.21*** (0.10)	-0.53*** (0.10)
Seed (level shift)	-0.53 (0.39)	-0.16 (0.38)	-1.30** (0.45)	-0.50 (0.43)
<i>(c) Seed and linear timing</i>				
Seed	-1.02* (0.40)	-0.34 (0.38)	-1.62*** (0.45)	-0.60 (0.43)
Months before primary	-0.62*** (0.07)	-0.28*** (0.06)	-0.81*** (0.07)	-0.40*** (0.06)
Seed gap absorbed (%)	78	81	74	78
Observations	129,997	129,997	156,340	156,340

Entry is the number of months between the state's first primary and the donor's first gift to the member in the first winning cycle (positive = before the primary), top-coded at 12 and bottom-coded at -6. All models include legislator $\times$ election, donor $\times$ year and donor $\times$ party fixed effects; "amount bins" adds 20 bins of first-cycle amount interacted with election number, so the seed coefficient differs slightly from Table 2, column (5), which pools the bins across elections. Coefficients in percentage points of the per-cycle lapse probability; standard errors two-way clustered by legislator and donor. The share absorbed is one minus the ratio of the seed coefficient in (c) to the seed coefficient alone. 1990–2016 cohorts, elections through 2018. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

–4.7 points). The earliest and latest first-campaign entrants thus both sustain support more often than donors entering during the general-election campaign. Post-election donors may seek access to a new incumbent, but timing alone does not establish their motive.

The piecewise model also asks whether nomination marks a separate change in durability. The estimated level shift is –0.5 points (SE 0.4) for interests and –1.3 (0.5) for PACs. The PAC shift is statistically significant, but shrinks to –0.7 (0.5) when post-general entrants are excluded and to –0.5 (0.4) after amount adjustment. Figure 4 examines ties formed close to the primary through a local descriptive comparison of second-election lapse rates, accounting for member and donor fixed effects. Within 30 days, the estimated differences are –0.4 percentage points (SE 2.2) for PACs and –0.4 (2.3) for interests, compared with a 9-point raw seed difference for this outcome. Bias-corrected estimates and alternative bandwidths yield similar conclusions (Online Appendix

Table A1).

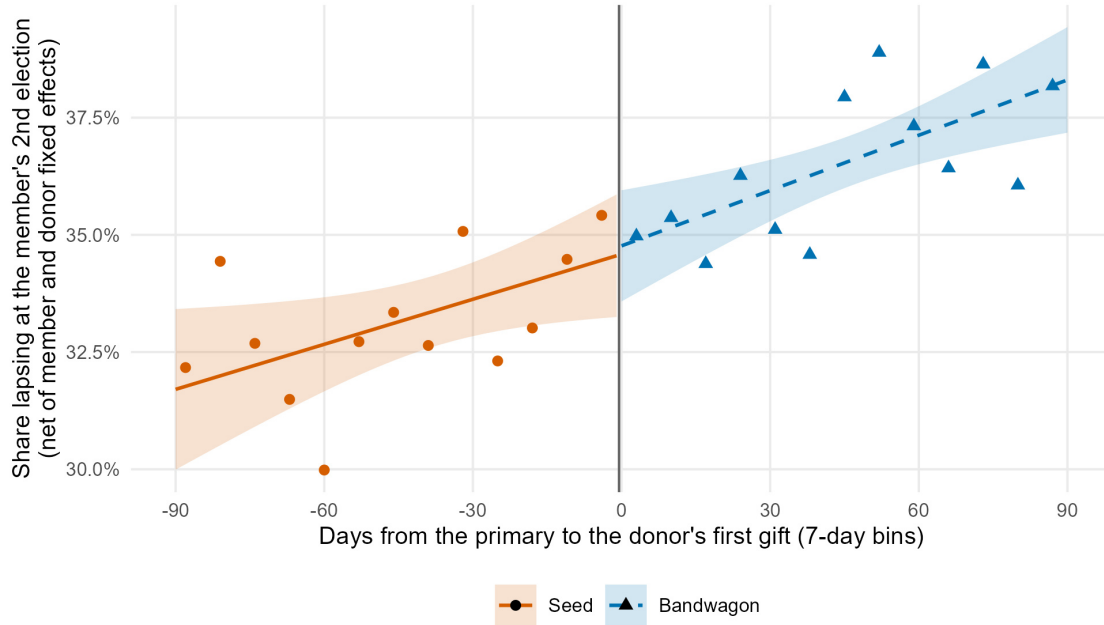


Figure 4: Share of PAC ties lapsing at the member's second election, by days from the primary to the donor's first contribution. Seven-day bins of outcomes net of member and donor fixed effects, with linear fits and 95% confidence bands on each side of the primary.

These local comparisons show no detectable break, but cannot identify the effect of nomination. A density test rejects continuity in entry dates (Cattaneo et al., 2020), and post-primary entrants give smaller first contributions, are less often unions, and more often support Republicans (Online Appendix Table A2 and Figure A2). Changes in donor composition could conceal or produce a difference at the primary. Excluding contributions within three days of the primary or dropping runoff states also yields no detectable difference. One of ten placebo cutoffs is significant at the 5 percent level (Online Appendix Table A8).

The informational value of nomination should be greater when candidates face a primary opponent. Online Appendix Table A10 compares the 142 members with uncontested nominations and the 632 with contested primaries. Among members with contested primaries, the PAC timing gradient is 1.08 points per month, compared with 0.65 among those with uncontested nominations (reported interaction difference 0.39, SE 0.09). Among similar-size ties, the gradients are 0.55 and 0.21. Seed coefficients differ in the same direction, though less sharply (−6.5 against −5.2 points). Within contested races, gradients are nearly identical for members winning by less than 20 points and those winning by more. Local comparisons in contested races again show no detectable break: within 30 and 60 days, ties formed just after nomination are, if anything, less likely to lapse (−1.0 and −2.4 points for PACs, both insignificant). The small piecewise shift appears in

lopsided contested races rather than close ones. These estimates provide limited support for a sharp nomination threshold, although realized vote margins do not directly measure the uncertainty donors faced before the primary. Using the same-party rival fundraising threshold of \$5,000 yields similar conclusions.

Members with earlier political careers offer another comparison. Those who previously held elected office attract more seed support: 25 percent of their PAC ties begin before nomination, compared with 16 percent for members without prior office. Yet their seed relationships are not more distinctive in durability. PAC seed coefficients and timing gradients are nearly identical across the groups (seed interaction 0.9, SE 0.8), while the interest-level seed difference is smaller among experienced members (by 2.0 points, SE 0.7). Prior state or federal legislative service yields the same pattern (Online Appendix Table A13). These comparisons show that the durability difference is not concentrated among members with previous officeholding experience. They do not test whether particular PACs had prior ties: candidates without elected experience may also have established professional, local, or party connections.

The context of early commitment matters, but the evidence does not reduce that context to the primary result. Timing predicts durability more strongly among members whose nominations were contested, while there is no clear increase with the closeness of the contest and no detectable local break at nomination. This is consistent with lasting relationships developing during the campaign rather than changing at a single electoral event. It is also consistent with donors already close to a candidate committing earlier and remaining longer. The analysis distinguishes these patterns from a sharp nomination threshold, while leaving the source of the underlying attachment open.

4.5 Do early and late ties respond differently to committee value?

Do early donors sustain support independently of a member's institutional position? Table 5, panel A, examines giving as members gain or lose committee seats with jurisdiction over donors' industries, using pair fixed effects. In the sample, 293 members gain and 337 lose a relevant seat for at least one donor. Holding such a seat is associated with a 7.8 point increase in PAC giving and a 6.8 point increase in interest giving. Interactions with seed status are -0.8 (SE 0.9) and -1.3 (0.8), respectively, and interactions with earlier entry are near zero. Figure 5 shows no evident pre-trend and an increase of 8 to 10 points for both groups after the first relevant assignment. Because 16 percent of ties gaining a relevant seat later lose it, these coefficients describe giving after first assignment rather than under continuous exposure. A cohort-specific event study following Sun and Abraham (2021), with observations censored at a subsequent loss and already-treated ties excluded as controls, yields nearly identical estimates (Online Appendix Table A11). This is a

sensitivity check on the first-assignment pattern, rather than an estimate of the effects of repeated gains and losses. Within these specifications, I find no detectable difference in responsiveness. Early commitment can coexist with giving that follows committee jurisdiction (Fourniaies and A. B. Hall, 2018).

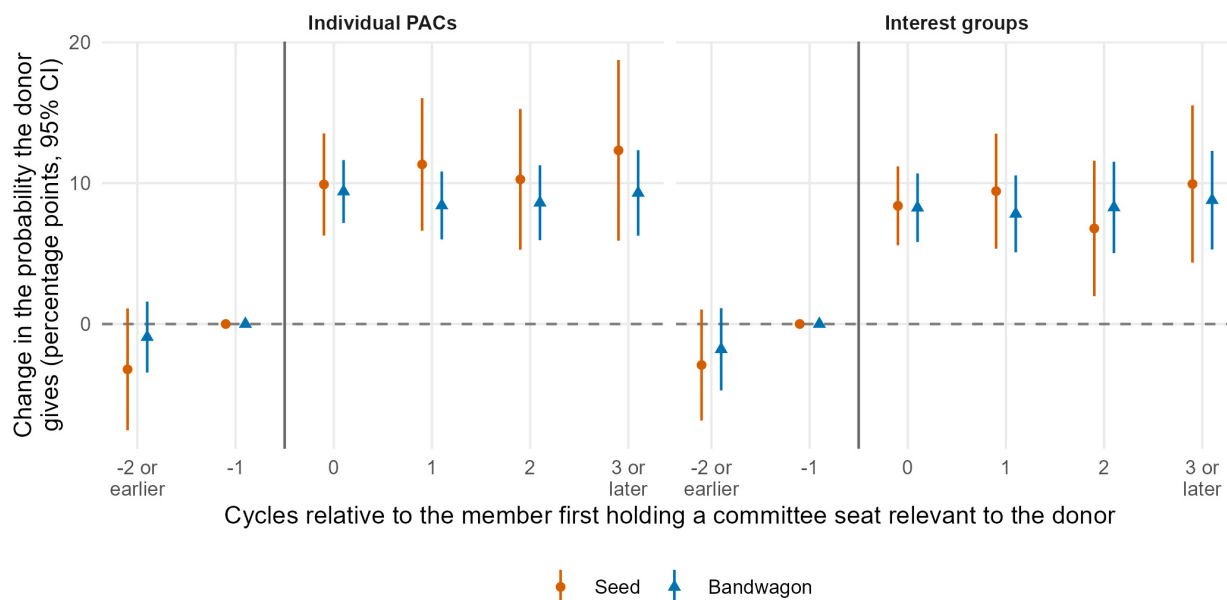


Figure 5: Change in the probability that the donor gives, in percentage points, by cycles relative to the member first holding a committee seat with jurisdiction over the donor's industry. Pair, legislator $\times$ election and donor $\times$ year fixed effects; never-gaining ties are controls. 95% confidence intervals.

Donor location provides a further indication of the relationships underlying continued support (panel B). In-state PACs account for 19.5 percent of seed ties and 13.4 percent of bandwagon ties. Among similar-size bandwagon ties, they are 14.9 points less likely to lapse than out-of-state PACs. The seed coefficient measures the difference among out-of-state donors: -3.1 points for PACs and -1.9 for interests. Among in-state ties, the corresponding differences are 0.1 points (95% CI -1.4 to 1.5) and 1.0 (-0.5 to 2.4), neither distinguishable from zero. Without amount adjustment, in-state seed ties are more durable (-3.4 and -2.0 points), though the difference remains smaller than among out-of-state donors. Early entry therefore distinguishes durability more clearly outside the member's state. Shared geography may already capture attachment, or lower lapse rates among local donors may leave less room for a seed difference.

Table 5: Committee value and donor location

	Interest groups	Individual PACs
<i>A. Gives in the cycle (pair, legislator $\times$ election and donor $\times$ year FE)</i>		
Relevant committee seat	6.8*** (0.8)	7.8*** (0.7)
Relevant seat $\times$ seed	-1.3 (0.8)	-0.8 (0.9)
Observations	177,511	278,805
Relevant seat $\times$ months before primary	-0.2 (0.1)	-0.1 (0.1)
<i>B. Hazard of first lapse (Table 2, column 5 specification)</i>		
Seed (out-of-state ties)	-1.9*** (0.3)	-3.1*** (0.4)
In-state donor	-6.6*** (0.6)	-14.9*** (0.8)
Seed $\times$ in-state	2.9*** (0.7)	3.1*** (0.8)
Seed difference among in-state ties	1.0 (0.7)	0.1 (0.7)
Observations	129,997	156,340

Panel A: all re-election cycles within the member's tenure; a relevant seat is a seat, in the Congress preceding the election, on a committee with jurisdiction over the donor's industry (hand-coded crosswalk in the replication materials). Months interaction from a separate model. Panel B: in-state means the PAC's FEC-registered state equals the member's state (for interests, more than half of the interest's first-cycle PACs). The model adds in-state and seed $\times$ in-state to Table 2, column (5), so the seed coefficient is the difference among out-of-state ties; the difference among in-state ties is the linear combination seed + seed $\times$ in-state. Coefficients in percentage points; standard errors two-way clustered by legislator and donor. 1990–2016 cohorts, elections through 2018. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

4.6 Robustness

The main findings persist across alternative definitions and samples (Online Appendix Table A5). These checks define a lapse as two consecutive cycles without giving; exclude ties below \$1,000, redistricting cycles, or the 1990 cohort; and restrict the sample to members whose service ends within the window. They also exclude the 15 candidacies without PAC receipts or retain only cycles receiving founding-donor money. Under the latter rule, estimates are -4.8 and -1.7 points for interests and -6.3 and -2.5 for PACs, without and with amount adjustment.

I also examine support dated against the candidate's own fundraising rather than the primary. Following the candidate-centered distinction in Case and Porter (2026), I classify ties beginning

within 90 days of the candidate's first observed PAC receipt as early. These ties are 5.7 points less likely to lapse for PACs and 4.6 points for interests; among similar-size ties, the differences are 2.4 and 2.3 points. The two definitions are moderately correlated (0.38 for PACs), and each predicts durability when included with the other (Online Appendix Table A12). This alternative captures entry near the start of observed PAC fundraising, which need not coincide with the start of the campaign.

Ending observation in 2012, before the rebuilt records, produces similar estimates (−4.7 and −1.4 points for interests; −6.4 and −2.3 for PACs). Interest retention through the fourth election is 64.2 versus 53.3 percent; entry-timing coefficients are −0.74 and −1.00 points per month. Local estimates again show no detectable primary-date discontinuity. Complementary log-log models and Cox models stratified by member or donor yield seed hazard ratios below one, including after amount adjustment (Online Appendix Table A3).

5 Discussion

This paper set out to understand when organized interests form lasting relationships with politicians and whether the timing of first support predicts their durability. Seed donors sustain support longer than bandwagon donors, and earlier entry generally predicts a lower probability of lapse. The same donor maintains its early relationships longer than its later ones. Interest-level support also resumes more often after a break, although the PAC resumption difference weakens after accounting for contribution size. The persistence of these relationships connects choices made during candidate emergence to the financial coalitions legislators maintain in office.

The conditions surrounding early support matter as much as the binary timing distinction. The durability difference is larger among PACs with narrower portfolios, consistent with early giving being more informative when an organization supports fewer candidates. Local donors are especially persistent, but seed and bandwagon ties receiving similar amounts have comparable durability within the member's state. The timing gradient is also steeper among members with contested nominations, while the seed difference is no larger among those with prior officeholding experience. These patterns suggest that early commitment carries information about particular relationships that is not captured by geography, recipient experience, or a donor's general giving patterns. They remain compatible with both prior attachment and commitment developed during the campaign.

The committee results show why investment and access should not be treated as mutually exclusive motives. Both seed and bandwagon donors increase giving when a member holds a relevant committee seat. A donor may sustain a relationship across elections and still adjust support

as the legislator’s institutional value changes. The more durable seed relationships therefore need not be insulated from the same access considerations that shape later giving. Continuing support may reflect both loyalty and expected returns (Rueda and Ruiz, 2025).

The evidence also clarifies which part of the investment argument receives support. Earlier and larger commitments predict persistence, but nomination does not consistently mark a separate change in the relationship. Local comparisons show no detectable break, including in contested races, and the small shift in one global PAC specification is no longer statistically distinguishable from zero after excluding post-general entrants or adjusting for amount. These patterns are compatible with organized interests shaping nominations and sustaining relationships with aligned legislators (Bawn et al., 2012; Hassell, 2018). They offer limited support for the narrower claim that support immediately before nomination creates an obligation distinct from support immediately afterward. Sorting and unobserved relationships prevent a causal interpretation of that comparison.

These findings carry implications for legislative representation. The interests supporting a candidate before nomination remain visible in the member’s financial coalition, even as incumbency attracts new donors. Founding contributors are a minority of all donors, but their relationships can persist for much of a legislative career. Interest-group engagement has been linked to legislative behavior (Garlick, 2022). Whether early supporters receive greater access or see their priorities reflected more consistently in lawmaking requires direct examination of those outcomes. The persistence documented here identifies the relationships through which such influence might operate.

6 Conclusion

When do enduring relationships between organized interests and politicians form? The evidence shows that support beginning before nomination remains distinctive after candidates reach Congress. Seed donors contribute a disproportionate share of first-campaign money and sustain their relationships longer than bandwagon donors, including within the same PAC’s giving history. Earlier entry predicts greater durability across much of the campaign, while post-election entrants constitute a separate group with comparatively persistent support. The timing of first commitment thus helps explain the composition of legislators’ continuing financial coalitions.

These results support an account of political investment that extends beyond the first election, while leaving the origins of attachment unresolved. Larger first-campaign contributions and earlier entry are associated with continued support. The timing gradient is steeper among members with contested nominations, but there is no detectable local break at the primary, and realized contest closeness does not clearly strengthen the pattern. Early and late donors also respond similarly

to relevant committee assignments. Lasting commitment can develop before officeholding while remaining responsive to the opportunities that office provides.

Future research should trace the relationships that precede a candidate's first House campaign. Linking PAC contributions across members' state and federal careers (Bonica, 2014) could identify donors who supported a member before the House race, subject to historical coverage and matching quality. Direct measures of policy agreement and earlier personal or organizational connections would further distinguish existing attachment from relationships built during the campaign. The central finding here is that early support leaves a lasting imprint on the financial coalitions legislators maintain, even as their electoral and institutional positions change.

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